

Carapace / Cortex Editorial Image Protocol

For “How We Help” and other story-led website pages

Purpose

These images are not infographics.

They should not try to explain every system component, repeat the page copy, or place all of the meaning inside a rounded card. Their job is to create visual breathing room and make the business promise feel tangible:

- work becomes clearer;
- the team gains leverage;
- complexity is handled without drama;
- useful systems emerge from real operations;
- people remain in control.

This visual family should sit beside the existing Cortex infographic system, not replace it.

Infographics explain how Cortex works.

Editorial images show what it feels like when Carapace helps a business work better.

Core Visual Direction

The image category

Use **editorial system scenes**.

These are cinematic, grounded, visually intentional scenes that suggest order, stewardship, momentum, and practical intelligence without becoming literal software diagrams.

They may include people, objects, environments, light, screens, materials, or abstracted physical systems. But they must always feel connected to real work.

The right emotional register is:

- intelligent, not flashy;
- calm, not sterile;
- premium, not corporate;
- technologically capable, not “sci-fi AI”;
- human-scale, not generic coworking stock photography;

- operational, not decorative.

The visual metaphor

The recurring idea is:

Messy work enters a clearer operating environment.

That can be shown through:

- scattered materials becoming ordered;
- multiple work paths converging into one deliberate flow;
- a person moving from overload toward clarity;
- a quiet, protected operating environment;
- one proven mechanism becoming a stable system;
- a team gaining reach without adding chaos.

Do not show literal dashboards, giant data visualizations, browser windows, or wordy screen interfaces unless the image is specifically intended to become a product demonstration.

Brand Palette and Material Language

Base palette

Use the existing Carapace/Cortex visual world, but reduce its density.

- **Midnight navy / near-black:** primary field and shadows
- **Warm ivory:** highlights, light sources, select surfaces
- **Electric blue:** system intelligence, movement, connection
- **Copper / ember orange:** human action, attention, commercial momentum
- **Soft green:** verified, healthy, aligned, safely operating
- **Muted slate blue:** atmosphere, secondary depth, quiet information

Color distribution

For editorial images, color should feel restrained.

- 65–75% dark navy, charcoal, black, or desaturated architectural tone
- 15–25% warm neutral light, textured surfaces, or low-key environmental color
- 5–10% electric blue, copper, or green accent light
- no rainbow interface effect
- no purple unless it is a subtle supporting shadow or reflective environmental note

Materials

Favor materials that make the technology feel durable and real:

- smoked glass
- dark brushed metal
- matte paper
- charcoal fabric
- warm wood
- frosted acrylic
- quiet architectural concrete
- softly illuminated surfaces
- tactile worktables
- dark screens with limited, non-legible glow

Avoid glossy “future office” chrome, giant holograms, floating code, overdone circuitry, or glowing brains.

Non-Negotiable Rules

Do

- keep the image mostly free of text;
- give each image one primary visual idea;
- use depth, shadow, and atmosphere;
- show one strong subject or visual anchor;
- leave room for responsive crop;
- let HTML carry headlines, labels, and calls to action;
- use small, subtle traces of the Cortex visual language where helpful;
- make people feel like competent operators, owners, specialists, or builders—not stock-photo employees.

Do not

- place a large rounded border around the whole image;
- build another all-in-one infographic panel;
- include readable UI, microcopy, tables, metrics, labels, or long lists;
- use smiling teams around a laptop;
- use generic office handshakes;
- use robots, glowing humanoid faces, AI brains, or floating heads;
- use neon cyberpunk city imagery;
- show a person pointing at a hologram;
- fill every background with decorative circuit lines;
- put Carapace or Cortex logos inside the image unless specifically requested.

The page itself should provide the brand identity. The image should provide atmosphere, meaning, and visual pull.

Image Type 1: Wide Responsive Story Image

Working name

Wide Storyfield

Use case

Use this image type for a section that needs to reset the rhythm of the page or establish the larger promise.

Best placements on “How We Help”:

1. directly below the opening statement; or
2. between the “How we help businesses” content and the first-engagement sequence; or
3. as a full-width visual before the Discovery Sprint section.

Use only one major Wide Storyfield on the page.

Role

The Wide Storyfield should make the visitor feel:

“This is not another AI product page. These people understand how work actually feels inside a business.”

It should suggest a business environment becoming more coherent, protected, and capable.

Format

- master generation: **2400 × 1600 px**
- master aspect ratio: **3:2**
- desktop display: crop or render between **3:2 and 16:9**
- mobile derivative: **4:5**
- export formats: WebP preferred, PNG only where transparency is needed
- target weight: ideally under 500 KB after web optimization

Mobile-safe composition

The critical subject must remain inside the center 56% of the canvas.

The outer left and right edges may carry atmosphere, secondary activity, or low-priority detail. They may not carry the story.

The desktop image should still make sense when cropped vertically on mobile.

Composition rules

- one dominant central or near-central focal point;
- depth should run from foreground to background;
- one side may be visually quieter to allow adjacent HTML copy;
- avoid strong left-to-right narratives that fail when cropped;
- do not put critical objects near the far edges;
- no headline baked into the image.

Suggested subject matter

Direction A — “The operating layer”

A dark, refined working environment viewed from slightly above. Multiple physical workstreams—papers, devices, project materials, notes, or light trails—converge toward a calm illuminated central workspace. One person may be present but not posed for camera. The feeling is that disorder is being gathered into a controlled operating layer.

Direction B — “From drag to rhythm”

An elegant, low-light workspace where scattered signals or physical tools are gradually organized into a visible path. A human operator is seen in profile or from behind, working calmly rather than frantically. The composition should imply flow without showing a literal process chart.

Direction C — “Private infrastructure”

A warm, architectural interior with a quiet protected core: a secure room, a contained workbench, or a central illuminated object that feels like a durable operational system. The image should suggest custody, restraint, and controlled access—not surveillance or fear.

Prompt framework

Create a cinematic editorial website image for Carapace, a company that helps businesses deploy private, governed AI workflows.

Concept:

[describe one real-work transformation]

Visual message:

Messy or disconnected work becomes calm, controlled, and useful.

Scene:

[describe the environment, human presence, physical objects, and central focal point]

Style:

Premium editorial technology photography with subtle architectural surrealism. Deep midnight navy, charcoal, warm ivory practical light, restrained electric-blue system glow, small copper accents, occasional soft green verified-state accents. Tactile materials: smoked glass, matte metal, dark wood, paper, fabric, soft reflective surfaces.

Composition:

3:2 master image. One clear focal subject inside the center 56% of the frame so it crops cleanly to 4:5 on mobile. Strong foreground, midground, and background depth. One quieter side for adjacent website copy. No text embedded in image.

Avoid:

UI cards, rounded infographic frames, readable dashboards, logos, robots, holograms, glowing AI brains, generic corporate stock poses, neon cyberpunk, busy circuitry, floating code, sci-fi control rooms.

Image Type 2: Half-Page Portrait Companion

Working name

Portrait Companion

Use case

Use this image type next to longer text sections. It should make the content feel human, crafted, and spacious without asking the visitor to read more information inside the image.

Best placements on “How We Help”:

- beside “How we help businesses”;
- beside “How a first engagement usually works”;
- beside “Why Carapace instead of one AI tool?”;
- optionally beside the Discovery Sprint invitation, though the form itself should remain visually simple.

Use two or three Portrait Companions on the page, not more.

Role

The Portrait Companion should make a section feel like a moment in a larger business story.

It is not a card illustration. It is a visual counterweight to copy.

Format

- master generation: **1600 × 2000 px**
- aspect ratio: **4:5**
- display on desktop: approximately half-page width
- display on mobile: full-width above or below the related copy
- export format: WebP preferred
- target weight: ideally under 350 KB after web optimization

Composition rules

- one scene;
- one subject, one object cluster, or one controlled environment;
- clear foreground anchor;
- breathing room at top and bottom;
- keep the important subject within the center 72% of the image;
- no embedded headline;
- no framed card, border, or internal caption strip;
- when paired with left-side copy, orient the subject subtly toward the copy;
- generate a horizontally mirrored variation when the image appears on the opposite side of the page.

Suggested portrait concepts

Portrait 01 — “Map the real work”

A close, editorial scene of a business owner, operator, or specialist working at a table with physical artifacts of a real process: papers, a notebook, a small device, a screen glow, task materials, a project plan. The visual should feel observant and intentional, not like staged productivity content.

Best paired with: “What we do” and “Who it’s for.”

Portrait 02 — “Start with one useful win”

A quiet experimental working environment in which one focused mechanism is being tested or assembled. It could be a structured desk, a small system on a wall, a carefully arranged set of working components, or one person making a deliberate adjustment.

Best paired with: Discover → Deploy → Measure → Expand.

Portrait 03 — “The team gets leverage”

A small team or business operator in a composed work environment where the signs of coordination are visible but understated: less clutter, a clear shared surface, movement or connection represented by light, ordered materials, and a feeling that the work is now carrying forward.

Best paired with: “Why Carapace instead of one AI tool?” or the Discovery Sprint section.

Prompt framework

Create a vertical editorial companion image for the Carapace website.

Concept:

[one human or operational moment related to the section]

Visual message:

A capable business team gains clarity, leverage, and controlled momentum through a better operating system.

Scene:

[describe one human subject, object cluster, or working environment]

Style:

Premium editorial technology photography with subtle architectural surrealism. Midnight navy and charcoal atmosphere, warm ivory practical light, restrained electric-blue connection glow, small copper moments for human action, occasional soft green for alignment. Textured and real: smoked glass, dark wood, paper, fabric, metal, low-light workspace.

Composition:

Vertical 4:5 image. One strong focal point within the center 72% of the frame. Preserve clean upper and lower breathing room. The visual should work beside website copy and at full width on mobile. No text inside the image.

Avoid:

Rounded cards, dashboards, text blocks, logos, generic office teams, headsets, stock-photo smiles, robots, holograms, overly futuristic labs, visible brand names, flashy neon color overload.

Page-Specific Art Plan: “How We Help”

01 — Wide Storyfield

Placement

Immediately after the opening hero copy and calls to action, before the “How we help businesses” sequence.

Concept

The work becomes visible.

Show a grounded business environment in which several scattered workstreams—documents, communications, task materials, devices, visual signals—are being gathered into a calm central operating point. The image should feel like the moment before a messy workflow becomes an intentional system.

What it communicates

- Carapace begins with real work, not abstract AI;
 - the business remains at the center;
 - the goal is clarity and momentum, not automation theater.
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02 — Portrait Companion: Workflow Discovery

Placement

Alongside the “What we do / Who it’s for / Why teams hire us” content.

Concept

See the work before changing it.

A thoughtful close scene of a person reviewing a real operation: working documents, physical planning tools, screens kept soft and illegible, subtle blue traces connecting otherwise separate elements.

What it communicates

- Carapace listens before it builds;
 - the work is practical;
 - the system begins with the actual bottleneck.
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03 — Portrait Companion: Practical Pilot

Placement

Opposite the “How a first engagement usually works” section.

Concept

Start small. Prove value.

A focused, controlled environment where one useful system is being tested or refined. The image should feel deliberate and modest in scale—not a giant enterprise command center.

What it communicates

- a pilot is a real operational win;
 - the work is governed;
 - growth follows proof, not hype.
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04 — Portrait Companion: Control Without Lock-In

Placement

Beside “Why Carapace instead of one AI tool?”

Concept

The business directs the destination.

A more architectural, abstract scene: one central protected workspace or operational core, with several potential pathways extending outward in restrained blue, copper, green, and dim violet light. The business environment remains the center; destinations remain secondary.

What it communicates

- model independence;
 - vendor flexibility;
 - custody and governance;
 - the company controls where work goes.
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Quality Gate

Approve an editorial image only when all of the following are true:

- It still makes sense at thumbnail size.
 - It has one clear emotional and visual message.
 - It feels connected to real work, not generic AI.
 - It has no important text baked into it.
 - It does not repeat the existing full-frame infographic language.
 - It crops cleanly on mobile without losing the subject.
 - It leaves enough visual quiet for the page copy to do its job.
 - It belongs to the Carapace visual world without looking like a repeat of the Solutions page.
 - It feels like a business gaining calm leverage, not a company buying “AI magic.”
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Final Direction

For this page, use images as **editorial pauses**, not content containers.

The existing Solutions infographics can remain the proof-heavy explanation layer. “How We Help” should feel more like walking into a capable, private operating environment: people understand the work, remove the drag, prove a useful win, and leave the business with something more stable than another tool.